SCHOOL CHOICE: FACTORS INFLUENCING SOMALI IMMIGRANT PARENTS' CHOICES FOR THEIR CHILDREN

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Research Question

What factors do Somali parents consider when making decisions about schooling for their elementary-aged children?

Significance

Parents have many choices for schooling their children, including public schools, charter schools, inter-district transfer, on-line learning, and home schooling.

Little is known about how recent immigrants think about schooling for their children, and there is no research on school choice within the Somali-American community. The study is an exploratory investigation of parent choice in an under-researched community.

Methodology

- A convenience sample was conducted with 10 Somali mothers, in the Somali language; interviews were conversational in structure.
- Notes were handwritten and elaborated on as soon as possible after the interview in order to preserve direct quotes.
- Collected data included: age, income, marital status, level of formal education, number of children, factors surrounding current school choices, general discussion of differences between schooling options available to families.
- Interview data was coded by question and summarized. Each interview was analyzed for themes and new issues that emerged. Cross-respondent analysis concluded the process.
- Reluctance to participate was noted; lack of interest in being tape recorded.
- Scheduling was complicated by Ramadan.

Demographic Data

- All respondents were mothers and 80% were married.
- Ages ranged between 40 to 49 years old.
- 80% of respondents described themselves as "low-income."
- 100% of respondents identified as Muslim.
- 60% of respondents were illiterate. Another 30% were semiliterate, meaning that they had varying degrees of ability to speak and write in English and Somali. Only one respondent was literate.



Findings

All parents are concerned about cultural compatibility.

- Eight out of ten parents whose children are girls are especially concerned about support for wearing the hijab.
- Seven out of ten parents reported considering services related to reducing language barriers (interpreters, etc.).
- Six reported that community representation was important: Some charter schools run by a board of teachers, community, and parent members (their community is represented).
- Nine out of ten report culture is something that mothers consider not only for their children but also themselves; parent resource availability (English language classes, etc.).
- Six out of ten stated charter schools hire elderly people and guardians or chaperons to help both students and parents, which supports the community.

Educational level of the parents matters.

- Less well-educated mothers (7/10) rely on friends and family members for advice about school choice.
- Better educated mothers (3/10) have less strong preferences for a particular school type (charter or public).

Ease of access an important consideration in choice of schooling.

- For some parents, availability of school choice options depends on the area families live (Some areas have no convenient charter schools).
- Sibling consideration was also a factor in parents' preferences.

Implications & Discussion

- Cultural considerations are most prominent, but are not easily classified as "wanting to be with people like us."
- Most parents, particularly those who are less well educated, lack systematic information about school choices. More written material is unlikely to help because many do not read well in either English or Somali.
- School choice may result in reduced opportunities for charter school students who do not have access to supplemental programs such as Upward Bound or have larger classes. Not all parents are aware of this.
- All schools need to consider whether they have the right kind of cultural and parent support. Rapid demographic shifts mean that schools may see quick changes in their populations.
- School districts and officials would do well to create programs that inform parents of the various choices and programs available to their children, but such programs must be culturally sensitive and delivered in ways that are culturally appropriate.
- Accommodations such as the establishment of parent liaison offices, the translation of written materials into Somali, the provision of information in an oral/auditory format, and the availability of interpreters would do much to increase parental involvement in schooling.

Limitations

- Respondents demonstrated low levels of trust during interviews and had serious questions about who will see their responses. They may not have been as forthcoming as desirable when answering questions.
- Setting up times and arranging locations at which to conduct interviews was extremely challenging in part because of constraints around appropriate social customs for women.
- Sample size was 10 mothers; more interviews would provide more data.



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Acknowledgement

Special thanks to Dr. Karen Seashore for her mentorship and the entire McNair team for their endless support to my project. Also, I would like to thank Melanie S. of the Student Parent HELP Center for her wonderful support with my project.